Why the head of the India Office did not recognise what the Times and the Indian government did, is perplexing.

Indeed, the Times was not the only one to question Curzon's apparent expertise in South Asian affairs. At the end of 1920, the decision had been taken by Cabinet to create a new Middle Eastern Department and to place it within the Colonial Office, rather than the Foreign Office.[145] *Unsurprisingly, Curzon took this as a personal affront, and commenced on a battle of wills with the secretary of state for colonial affairs, Winston Churchill.Difficulties arose almost immediately over the exact remit of the new department, with Curzon complaining in a letter to his wife in February 1921 that he had spent the day arguing with Churchill in Cabinet over the Middle East: 'He wants to grab everything into his new Dept, and to be a sort of Asiatic Foreign Secretary. I absolutely declined to agree with this...'*[146] *Two days later, Churchill informed his own wife: 'Curzon will give me lots of trouble and have to be half flattered and half overborne. We overlap horribly. I do not think he is much good.'*[147]

For the foreign secretary, matters became worse when Churchill began to insist on making speeches within and outside of Cabinet on issues relating to foreign affairs. As Curzon complained to Lloyd George, in June 1921: 'I have for some time been a good deal disturbed at Winston's unauthorised and sometimes not too helpful incursions into Foreign affairs which do not render my task or position any the more easy...'[148] While the prime minister agreed with Curzon 'that it is most improper and dangerous for any Minister [other than the foreign secretary] to make a pronouncement upon questions of foreign policy', there was little he could do to temper Churchill.[149] When Curzon complained directly to the colonial secretary,[150] he simply received the dismissive reply that Churchill always spoke 'with very great care on these matters'.[151] Curzon, however, was not prepared to let the issue rest, countering that he could not 'admit that the Minister of a Dept other than that of Foreign Affairs has any right without consultation with the FO to make speeches on Foreign Affairs, merely because he holds strong views upon them...'[152]